

My name is Iolanda Navone and I recently graduated from La Sapienza University of Rome. Maria has been my co-supervisor for my master thesis on the role of matter creation on cosmological dynamics, and later supervised my work for the Asian Winter Internship at NAOJ, an opportunity that I would have never heard of had she not encouraged me to apply.

At the beginning of our collaboration, we co-authored my first paper remotely; due to her remarkable responsiveness - often replying to emails late into the night to clear my doubts and help me meet deadlines – it took me days to realize that we were living in time zones eight hours apart. This was my first real sense of her generosity and dedication to collaboration.

Our time working together at NAOJ has been enriching beyond my expectations, not only because of her help in studying a new cosmological model, but because of all the insights and stories I was able to draw from her rich and diverse experience in academia. In fact, knowing that I had found myself at a crossroads between pursuing a PhD and different paths, Maria made sure to share with me anything that would help me visualize my possible life as a researcher, giving me a concrete idea of what kind of obstacles and rewarding experiences I should expect. When she realized that I was broadly interested in many areas of physics and still in the process of identifying a specific research direction, she started suggesting seminars for me to attend to help me explore different fields. Even more importantly, she put effort into providing me with all the tools and support I would need to fund my work in the future or find the right fit for a PhD, and offered me opportunities for growth that are hard to find for graduate students.

Her work ethic and optimistic attitude encouraged me to be at my most productive, but she never demanded more than what I freely committed to: I particularly appreciated how she took the time to ask for my priorities and to establish together our reciprocal expectations from the beginning, ensuring a healthy and enjoyable work environment.

Even outside of the work environment, she made sure I had a positive experience in Japan offering a helpful reference point when I needed it and suggesting nice breaks together.

In general, what surprised me when working on projects together is that despite my limited experience compared to her considerable expertise, Maria made me feel fully listened to in every interaction, treating my opinions with a level of consideration and respect that rarely feels this genuine.

When I did come to a decision about my future that Maria was critical about, she first asked if I wanted her opinion, and only then she shared her thoughts on the

matter – trying to help me think about my decision, rather than to dissuade me. I appreciated her sincerity but most of all I appreciated how, before that conversation took place, she had already given me her unconditional support, actively helping me reaching a goal she did not even agree with. She could see how motivated I was and she did not need to understand why in order to be on my side. This is the kind of respect Maria always showed me.

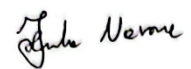
I am grateful for having seen first-hand through her example what it means to approach one's work with full engagement, care and responsibility – I will carry this experience with me moving forward.

(Also: I had fun.)

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Iolanda Navone

Iolandanavone999@gmail.com

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Iolanda Navone". The script is cursive and fluid, with the first name "Iolanda" written in a larger, more prominent hand than the last name "Navone".